



Globally, too, there are just a handful of companies that control all the top luxury labels. French conglomerate LVMH Moët Hennessy Louis Vuitton is home to brands such as Bvlgari, Tiffany, Dior, etc., while the Kering Group manages brands such as Gucci and Alexander McQueen.

IN OCTOBER LAST year, RBL invested in designer Manish Malhotra's company MM Styles for a 40 per cent minority stake. "We're bringing additional changes and innovations on the platter. With beauty, jewellery, virtual store, NFT already on the horizon, I plan on taking these ventures to newer

heights. With Reliance, we hope to go more corporate and systematic. It's basically corporatisation of Indian fashion that's going to happen now. This will help us with the technology and sustainability," says Malhotra, who started out as a movie costume designer three decades ago with *Swarg* (1990), and founded his label in 2005. Malhotra has designed costumes for several hundred films, and also has jewellery and make-up lines. Post the collaboration with RBL, Malhotra has launched Diffuse, a bridge-to-luxury label. "While initially the plan was to bridge the gap between youth and couture, we decided to make a separate line altogether to make the offerings consciously-priced and available," he says.

Another designer who is happy to have entered into a partnership with RBL is Rahul Mishra, the first Indian designer to showcase at Paris Haute Couture week. RBL has entered into a 60:40 joint venture with Rahul Mishra to create a new ready-to-wear brand. The plan is to have a worldwide footprint with dedicated flagship stores at fashion capitals around the world in the next five years. While Mishra started his career with ready-to-wear with his collections being shown at the Paris Fashion Week for several years, and it formed 50 per cent of his business till 2020 (the balance being couture), post the pandemic the brand has become synonymous with couture with both Hollywood and Bollywood celebrities donning it. "Couture gave us a major jump in revenue since prices are higher. Between 2020 and 2021 the company grew 100 per cent and last year, too, growth was around 70 per cent," says Mishra, adding that he focussed on couture because supply chains were disrupted as were interactions with wholesale buyers.

However, now with the JV with RBL, he is all set to re-enter the ready-to-wear market and create a new brand for both Indian and global markets. "If you have to dream of establishing a global brand out of India, it has to be ready-to-wear. RBL will help us achieve scale. I could be supplying across the globe but nothing beats having a flagship store. We are looking at an omnichannel presence in cities like London and Paris. RBL enables that," says Mishra. He gives the example of Gucci, saying that it was a \$100-million brand while it was with the family but with the Kering Group it has grown to be a \$12-billion brand. "That kind of growth comes through corporatisation." He adds that RBL is helping create structure